



New Places, New Feelings: How Primal World Beliefs and Mobility Behaviors Predict Momentary Subjective Experience

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Introduction

Social Exploration-Exploitation Trade-Off

- Exploring new opportunities vs. exploiting familiar ones⁽¹⁾
- Person-level factors: motivation to seek novelty, avoid risk, sense of security, affective state⁽¹⁾

Mobility Behaviors

- Physical exploration links to social exploration
- How often and how long people visit places
- Linked to subjective well-being, depression, loneliness and affect^(2, 3)

Primal World Beliefs

- Construals of the overall world⁽⁴⁾
- 2 key Primals: safe and enticing

Momentary Affect

- Negative affect increases exploitation⁽¹⁾
- More exploration predicts higher positive affect, across ages⁽⁵⁾

Activity Typicality

- High typicality: Rituals and habits support emotional stability, social connection (perceptions of unity), and well-being^(6,7)
- Low typicality: Novelty-seeking raises arousal, affect, risk-taking⁽⁵⁾

Although past studies have examined mobility behaviors and primal world beliefs separately in relation to emotional well-being, few have explored how these two factors interact to shape momentary subjective experiences. The present study addresses this gap by asking: At the between-person level, how do primal world beliefs and mobility behaviors interact to predict momentary subjective experience (e.g., affect and activity typicality)?

Methods

Participants

- UVA undergraduates; fall 2023
- N = 374; 41% Black, 36% White

Measures

- Passive Location Tracking (recorded once per min)
 - Total Visits: Number of visits to each unique location
 - Visit Duration: Time spent at a location before moving to another
 - Total Visit Duration: Cumulative time spent at each location
- Primal World Beliefs
 - Primal Brief Inventory
 - Belief in a safe / enticing world
- Ecological Momentary Assessment (3x a day)
 - Momentary Affect: How are you feeling right now? (1-7)
 - Activity Typicality: How typical is your current activity? (1-7)

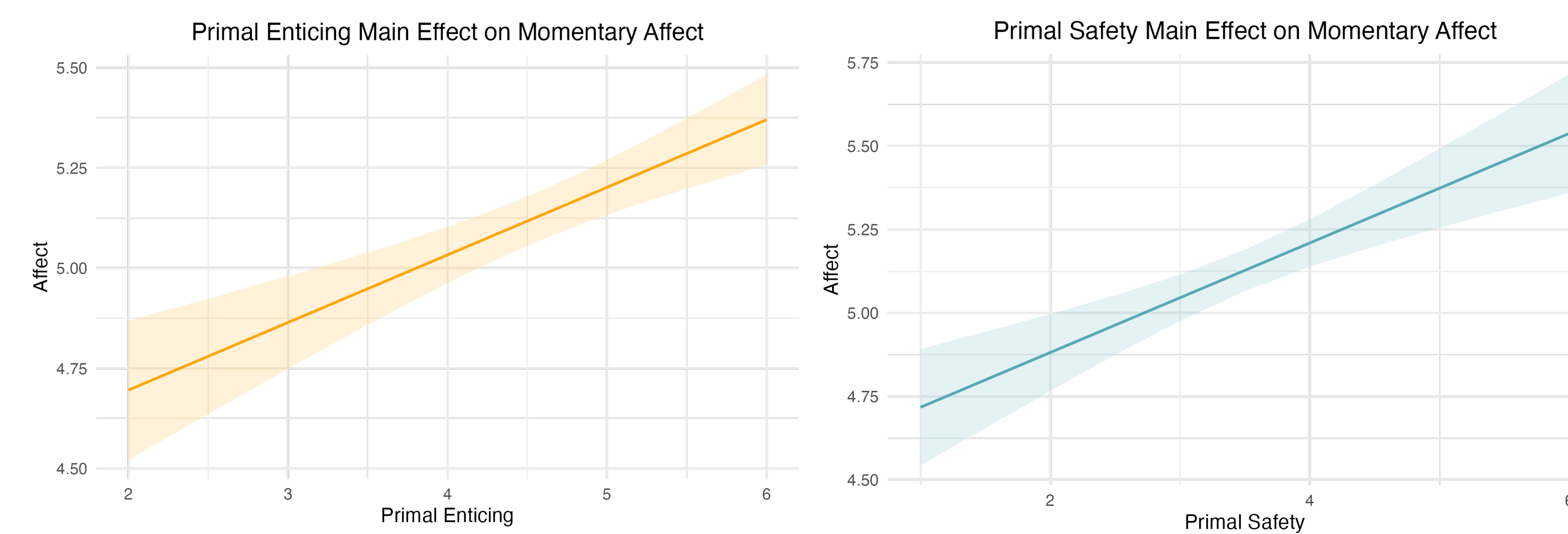
Analyses

- Multilevel mixed-effects generalized linear models for momentary affect and activity typicality

Results

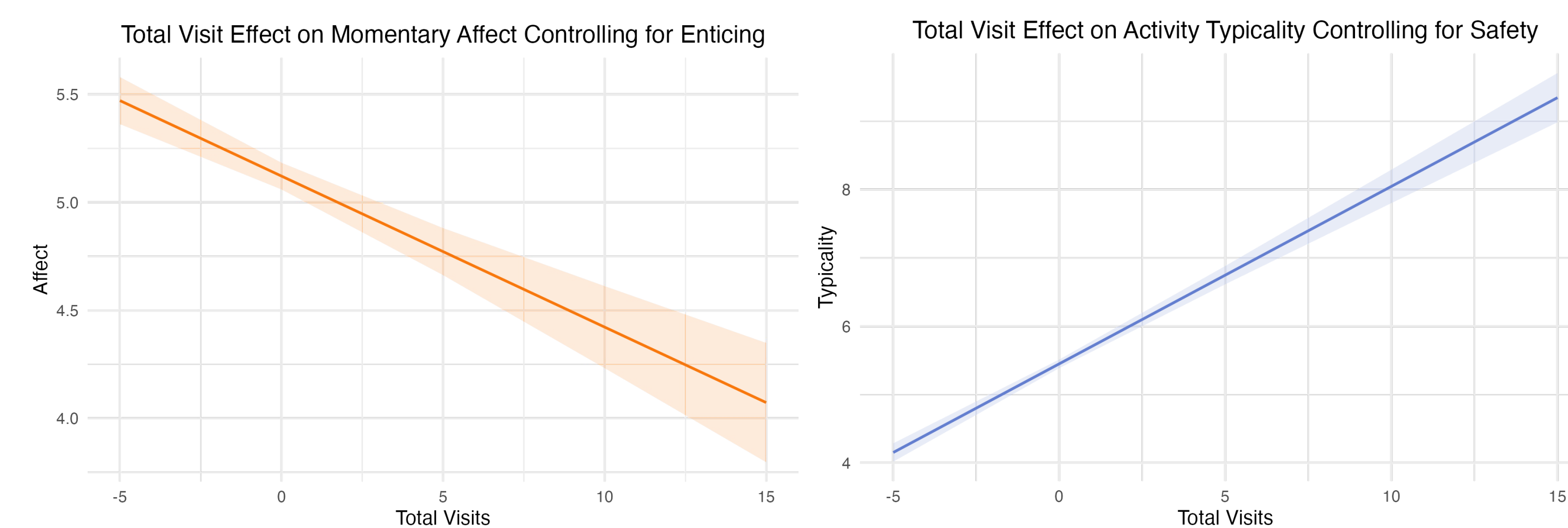
Do primal word beliefs predict momentary affect? (below)

- Significant main effects: between-person enticing in all three models, between-person safety in all three models



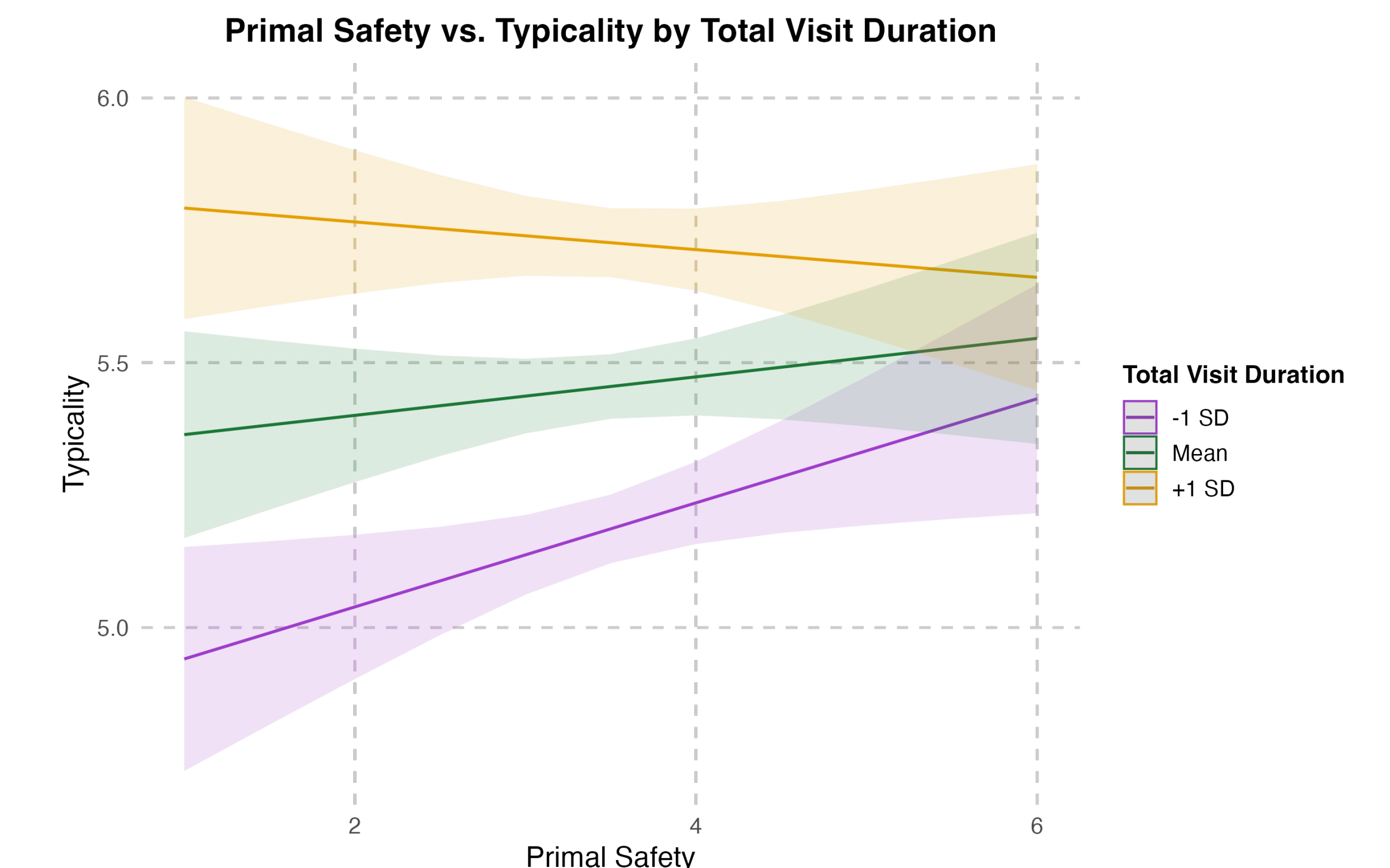
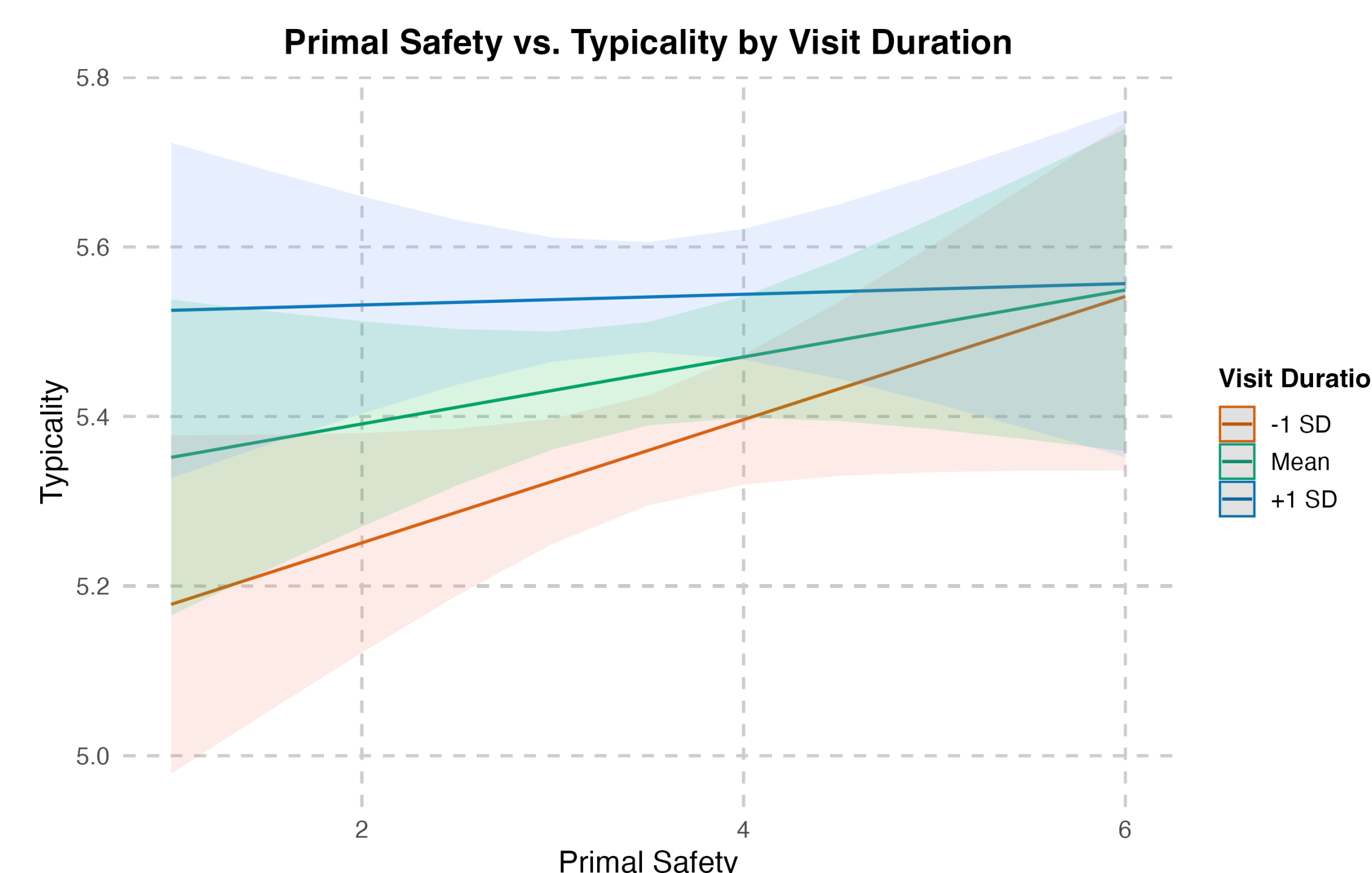
Do mobility behaviors predict affect and activity typicality? (below)

- Significant main effects: total visits in all four models, controlling for either primal enticing or safety



How do mobility behaviors and primal safety interact to predict activity typicality? (below and right)

- Among people with a strong belief in a *safe* world, extended stays in one location were associated with engagement in rarer activities.



Discussion

Conclusions

- Both enticing and safe world beliefs predicted higher momentary affect.
- Affect was lower in familiar locations, higher in novel ones.
- Being in more frequently visited locations was associated with more typical, routine behavior at that moment.
- Among individuals with strong safe world beliefs, longer stays were linked to more novel activities at that moment.

Limitations

- Limited external validity due to college student sample.
- Correlational design precludes causal inference between beliefs, mobility, and subjective experiences.

Future Work

- What is the direction of causality? Do mobility and world beliefs influence affect and activity typicality, or vice versa?
- How do specific location attributes (e.g., crowd density, social context) interact with world beliefs to predict subjective experiences?

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